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WHAT CAN BE DONE?

The previous chapter argued that the build up to the 2015 elections excluded the Rohingyas from any vestige of civic or political life in Myanmar, leaving them without any official documents and increasingly held in what are becoming permanent refugee camps. Unless something happens to reverse this trend, it is highly likely that the mass refugee flows of previous years will be repeated whenever the weather systems allow safe passage on the Andaman Sea.

As we saw in Chapter 5, peace-time genocides are exceptionally rare. Rwanda is the most recent and, crucially, in that case the outside world ignored all the warnings and only reacted after the events. This forces a practical question: just what can the outside world do to prevent genocide in Myanmar?

The ideal response is clear. Stand up to the regime; demand they abide by the UN Charter on citizenship and nationality; insist that those directly implicated in the 2012 and 2013 violence in Rakhine face charges of preparing for and inciting genocide at the International Criminal Court. Rohingyas living in the camps have indicated far more modest demands: citizenship; the right to return to their homes; and freedom of movement.[1]

Few observers are so confident as to identify a single simple solution to a problem that has been allowed to escalate over more than forty years. Some have proposed steps that a given organisation might be able to undertake. So ASEAN parliamentarians have proposed that the issue of Myanmar's persecution of the Rohingyas be a permanent item on the agenda of future meetings,[2] not least since the refugee crises now present a problem for all states in the region. Linked to this, they suggest offering practical help to build better community relations in Rakhine and to ensure